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Papua New Guinea

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I. Process for the preparation of the report

1. This National Report (Report) has been prepared by the Government of the Independent State of Papua New Guinea (the Government) in accordance with the General Guidelines for the Preparation of Information under the Universal Periodic Review (UPR) and presents progress made, since the third-cycle review in implementing recommendations and advancing the promotion and protection of human rights. The report reflects legislative, policy, institutional and administrative measures adopted during the reporting period, while also identifying continuing challenges, capacity constraints and national priorities requiring further action and international cooperation. The Government considers the UPR to be an important mechanism for strengthening accountability, improving public policy, and reinforcing the integration of human rights into national development planning.

2. The Report draws primarily upon the Government's comprehensive assessment of implementation of the 161 recommendations presented during Papua New Guinea's (PNG) third-cycle UPR. This assessment was undertaken through an inter-agency technical review coordinated by the Government through the National Mechanism for Implementation Reporting and Follow-up (NMIRF) and supported by the United Nations (UN) Country Team. Through a national workshop held in Port Moresby from 23 to 27 February 2026, participating agencies reviewed progress against each recommendation, identified legislative and policy developments, assessed implementation status, highlighted remaining gaps and clarified institutional responsibilities for follow-up. This process established a common national framework for reporting and future implementation.

3. Preparation of the Report was informed by broad-based consultations involving the Government departments and agencies, constitutional offices, civil society organizations, faith-based organizations, organizations of persons with disabilities, women's organizations, youth representatives, development partners and the UN system. These consultations culminated in the National UPR Consultation and Validation Workshop held on 24–25 July 2026, during which participants reviewed successive drafts of the report, verified information, identified implementation gaps, and proposed priorities for the next reporting cycle.

4. The Government regards the Universal Periodic Review as an important mechanism for continuous improvement rather than a periodic reporting obligation. The Government is committed to strengthening implementation, monitoring and follow-up through enhanced inter-agency coordination, improved human rights data systems, greater stakeholder participation and closer alignment between human rights commitments, the Medium-Term Development Plan IV, the Sustainable Development Goals and national sectoral planning frameworks. The review process has reinforced the Government's commitment to transparent governance, inclusive service delivery, gender equality, disability inclusion, anti-corruption, climate resilience and the progressive realization of human rights throughout the country.

5. The Government also considered information drawn from national legislation, sectoral reports, administrative data, national statistical systems, independent oversight institutions, previous treaty body observations, the Voluntary National Review (VNR) on the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), stakeholder submissions and the UN Country Team compilation. The Government recognizes the importance of strengthening national human rights data systems and improving the availability of disaggregated data to support evidence-based policy development and future reporting.

II. Implementation of recommendations of previous cycles

A. Developments in the human rights normative and institutional framework

1. Constitutional and statutory framework for promotion and protection of human rights

6. Since the third-cycle review, Papua New Guinea has undertaken significant legislative and institutional reforms to strengthen the national framework for the promotion and protection of human rights. These reforms include the abolition of the death penalty; amendments to strengthen responses to sorcery accusation-related violence; enactment of the Family Protection (Amendment) Act 2022, the Civil and Identity Registration Act 2024, the Counter-Terrorism Act 2024, the Protected Areas Act 2024 and the Disability Services Act 2025.

2. Ratification of and accession to international human rights instruments

7. PNG continues to review its legal, policy and institutional frameworks to assess the implications of ratifying additional international human rights instruments, including the Convention against Torture and Other Cruel, Inhuman or Degrading Treatment or Punishment (CAT), the Optional Protocol to CAT (OP-CAT), the Optional Protocol to CEDAW (OP-CEDAW), and the International Convention for the Protection of All Persons from Enforced Disappearance (CPED). The Government remains committed to strengthening cooperation with UN human rights mechanisms and to progressively aligning domestic legislation with international human rights standards, where appropriate and consistent with national priorities.

3. Treaty reporting and cooperation with human rights mechanisms

8. In 2024, PNG submitted its Combined Second and Third Periodic Report under the Convention on the Rights of the Child and has continued work towards meeting outstanding reporting obligations under CEDAW and CRPD. Efforts have included improved inter-agency coordination, technical assistance and capacity-building support to strengthen reporting, implementation and follow-up processes. PNG remains committed to constructive engagement with treaty bodies and other human rights mechanisms.

9. PNG has continued to ensure that there is effective coordination of treaty reporting and engagement with international human rights mechanisms. In 2023, the National Executive Council approved the establishment of the National Mechanism for Implementation, Reporting and Follow-up (NMIRF) to strengthen coordination of treaty reporting, implementation and follow-up across Government. Co-chaired by the Department of Foreign Affairs (DFA) and the Department of Justice and Attorney General (DJAG), the NMIRF provides an institutional platform to improve inter-agency coordination, clarify treaty custodianship, strengthen data collection and support systematic implementation of recommendations arising from the Universal Periodic Review and treaty bodies. Continued efforts will focus on operationalizing the mechanism, strengthening institutional capacity and establishing a national recommendation tracking database (NRTD).

10. PNG has a standing invitation for Special Procedures since 2011. The Government acknowledges that several visit requests remain pending and will continue to engage with mandate holders where visits can support national priorities, capacity-building and constructive dialogue. The Government also welcomes continued technical assistance from OHCHR, the broader United Nations system, development partners, and civil society on treaty reporting, ratification analysis, legal harmonization and implementation of recommendations.

4. National Human Rights Institution (NHRI)

11. PNG continues efforts towards establishing an NHRI consistent with the Paris Principles. The DJAG Human Rights Secretariat working with an inter-agency technical working committee (TWC) supported by the European Union and the United Nations, has advanced draft enabling legislation and institutional proposals to the National Executive Council.

12. The Government is finalizing a draft Constitutional amendment and enabling legislation to establish a national human rights institution fully compliant with the Paris Principles, with 'A status' accreditation as the goal. The Government remains committed to progressing the legislative and institutional measures necessary for the establishment and operationalisation of an independent NHRI.

5. National Human Rights Action Plan

13. PNG has progressed the development of a National Human Rights Action Plan namely the Strategic Plan on Human Rights 2024–2029 which was launched in August 2024 and intended to provide a coordinated framework for the promotion and protection of human rights and implementation of accepted human rights recommendations. The Strategic Plan is intended to strengthen coordination across government agencies and support a systematic approach to human rights implementation, monitoring, and reporting.

14. In July 2026, the Government launched the National Human Rights Policy, marking a significant milestone following decades of advocacy for a comprehensive national human rights framework. The Policy seeks to promote access to justice and public services, address gender-based violence, strengthen law and order, safeguard land rights and improve accountability across public institutions.

15. The National Rights Policy includes measures to ensure the protection of human rights defenders, journalists, community advocates, women human rights defenders, environmental defenders, whistleblowers, witnesses and key populations, and others who raise concerns about abuse, corruption, environmental harm and ineffective service delivery.

16. The Government acknowledges that reliable data is essential for implementation and has identified gaps in disaggregated human rights data and statistics across all sectors. This will enable closer alignment of UPR implementation with Papua New Guinea’s VNR and SDG reporting, the national SDG data portal and sectoral statistics.

17. Together, the Human Rights Strategic Plan and National Human Rights Policy provide the foundation for a coordinated national approach to the protection and promotion of human rights and complement the mandate of an independent National Human Rights Institution once this is established.

B. Promotion and protection of human rights on the ground

1. Business and human rights

18. PNG continues to promote consideration of human rights within broader development and governance processes, including in relation to business activities. Efforts have focused on increasing awareness of responsible business conduct and exploring approaches to align national frameworks with the UN Guiding Principles on Business and Human Rights and developing a national action plan in consonance with the Strategic Plan on Human Rights 2024-2029.

2. Good governance and anti-corruption

19. PNG remains committed to combating corruption and promoting good governance through the work of the Independent Commission Against Corruption (ICAC). ICAC was established under the Constitution and the *Organic Law on the Independent Commission Against Corruption* 2019, which provides the legal framework for its functions, powers and independence. The ICAC became operational during the reporting period and has strengthened cooperation with other agencies.

20. The Constitutional and legislative framework safeguards the autonomy and operational independence of ICAC, enabling it to carry out its mandate without improper influence or interference. ICAC is responsible for the prevention, investigation and prosecution of corruption-related offences, as well as promoting integrity, accountability and transparency across public institutions.

21. ICAC participates in the Anti-Money Laundering and Counter-Terrorist Financing National Coordinating Committee and has pursued memoranda of understanding and information-sharing arrangements with financial, regulatory, tax, immigration, customs and securities authorities. The Government sees the need to strengthen ICAC, improve asset recovery, update the National Anti-Corruption Action Plan, protect whistleblowers, improve public participation and access to information, and deepen cooperation among ICAC and all anti-corruption and law enforcement bodies.

22. Going forward, the Government will update a number of key instruments including the National Anti-Corruption Strategy 2010-2030, the National Anti-Corruption Plan of Action 2026-2030, the amendments to the Whistleblowers Act, the Proceeds of Crime Act, and the Anti-Money Laundering and Counter-Terrorism Financing framework.

3. Constitutional guarantees of fundamental freedoms

23. PNG remains committed to protecting the rights to freedom of expression and publication, freedom of assembly and association, and freedom of information, as guaranteed under the Constitution. These rights are protected under Section 46 (Freedom of Expression and Publication), Section 47 (Freedom of Assembly and Association) and Section 51 (Right to Freedom of Information) of the Constitution. These constitutional protections support democratic governance, public participation, accountability and the enjoyment of civil and political rights.

4. Access to information and transparency

24. The Government continues to advance transparency, accountability and public participation in governance through implementation of the National Right to Information Policy and ongoing efforts towards the development of a legislative framework for access to information. These initiatives are intended to improve the public's ability to obtain information held by public institutions and promote openness in government decision-making processes.

25. The Government continues to undertake legislative and policy reforms to give practical effect to section 51 of the Constitution in a manner balances the public's right to information with the need to protect legitimate interests, including privacy, national security and confidential information. These efforts are aimed at ensuring that access to information arrangements are consistent with democratic governance principles and international good practice.

C. Gender equality and women’s empowerment

1. Legal and policy framework on gender equality and women's empowerment

26. The policy framework for gender equality has been strengthened through the adoption of the Gender Equality and Women's Empowerment Policy 2025-2035, which provides a comprehensive framework to advance women's participation in leadership and decision-making, economic empowerment, health, education and training, prevention of gender-based violence, climate resilience and access to services. The Policy also promotes gender mainstreaming across government institutions and development programmes.

27. The Government has continued implementation of Gender Equity and Social Inclusion (GESI) approaches across the public sector and has supported initiatives aimed at improving access to education, healthcare, economic opportunities and public services for women and girls.

28. The adoption of the National Prevention Strategy 2025-2030 further recognises the importance of women's participation and empowerment as a key element in preventing gender-based violence and sorcery accusation-related violence and promoting inclusive and resilient communities.

29. The Government hosted a Women Peace and Security (WPS) Summit on 23 to 24 June 2026 that strengthened the commitment to develop a National Action Plan on Women Peace and Security.

2. Women's leadership and political participation

30. The Constitution provides for three nominated members of parliament, and ongoing advocacy on Temporary Special Measures continues to advance use of these provisions to provide reserved seats for women and persons with disabilities. Positive steps have been achieved, for example, in the Autonomous Region of Bougainville (AROB), three regional seats for women were provided in the House of Representatives as Temporary Special Measures (TSM) promoting the involvement of more women in politics. A Joint Parliamentary Women's Caucus has been established, bringing together women members of the National Parliament and the Bougainville House of Representatives. The Constitutional and Law Reform Commission (CLRC), DJAG and DFCDR's Office for Development of Women (ODW) have all undertaken or supported reviews relating to TSM for women.

31. Official labour and parliamentary data confirm the challenge: women's representation in the National Parliament remains below 3 per cent (3 out of 118 members), while women's participation in formal and paid employment and business ownership remains substantially lower than men's.

32. To encourage women participation in leadership, in 2026 Parliament passed the amendments to the *Organic Law on the Integrity of Political Parties and Candidates* 2001 (OLIPPAC). The amendments require all political parties to endorse at least 10% women candidates beginning with the 2027 elections. This quota is backed by penalties such as deregistration and fines for parties that fail to comply in two consecutive elections. Alongside this, initiatives like the UN-supported *Women Make the Change* program are working to strengthen women's leadership and party systems, while some party leaders have publicly committed to supporting female candidates. These steps mark a significant policy shift toward gender equality in PNG politics, but the true measure of progress will depend on how effectively parties recruit, support, and promote women candidates in the upcoming elections.

3. Women's economic empowerment

33. PNG continues to promote women's economic empowerment through the Gender Equality and Women's Empowerment Policy 2025-2035, the National Financial Inclusion Strategy 2023-2027 led by the Bank of PNG and the Centre for Excellence in Financial Inclusion (CEFI), and broader national development frameworks, including PNG Vision 2050, the Small and Medium Entrepreneurship Policy 2016, and the Small and Medium Entrepreneurship Master Plan 2016-2030. These frameworks seek to increase women's access to finance, entrepreneurship opportunities, financial literacy and participation in economic activities.

34. The Government has supported women's access to financial services, business development and entrepreneurship through CEFI programmes and initiatives such as the PNG Women's Business Resource Centre, which provides business training, mentoring and financial literacy support to women-owned enterprises.

35. Progress has been made to increase women's participation in economic activities. World Bank data indicate that female labour force participation was approximately 46.4 per cent in 2023. The Government is also reviewing the *Employment Act* 1978 and the *Industrial Relations Act* 1962 (Chapter 174) to remove discriminatory provisions, promote equal opportunity and improve conditions for women's participation in formal employment.

36. Despite these efforts, women continue to face barriers in accessing finance, markets and formal employment opportunities, particularly in rural and remote communities. The

Government remains committed to expanding financial inclusion, supporting women-owned businesses and increasing women's participation in the formal economy.

4. Gender based violence

37. PNG reaffirms its commitment to eliminating gender-based violence, domestic violence and sexual violence, through implementation of the Gender Equality and Women's Empowerment Policy 2025-2035, the National Strategy to Prevent and Respond to Gender-Based Violence 2026-2035, and the Family Protection Act 2013 (as amended). These frameworks provide a coordinated approach to prevention, survivor protection, access to justice, service delivery and accountability.

38. The Government has renewed its national response to GBV through the National Strategy to Prevent and Respond to Gender-Based Violence 2026-2035, launched by the Prime Minister in March 2026. The Strategy provides a properly costed framework for prevention, response, coordination and accountability and is under the oversight of both the National Parliament, through the Permanent Parliamentary Committee on Gender Equality and Women Empowerment (PPC GEWE), and the National Gender-Based Violence Secretariat (NGBVS) and the Office for Development of Women (ODW) under the Department for Community Development and Religion (DFCDR). It builds on standards laid out in the Family Protection Act, the Family Protection (Amendment) Act, the Criminal Code amendments addressing acts of SARV.

39. Implementation of the GBV Strategy is anchored on the work of the National GBV Secretariat, provincial GBV secretariats and Family and Sexual Violence Units across the country. The implementation of the Strategy is to be funded at approximately K180 million per year over the next 10 years, requiring coordinated investments from Government, development partners and the private sector.

40. The Government recognizes that all persons are entitled to protection from violence, abuse, arbitrary treatment, denial of essential services and unlawful discrimination. The HIV/AIDS Management and Prevention Act demonstrates national commitment to address stigma, discrimination and unauthorized disclosure affecting people living with or affected by HIV and key population groups. The Government will continue to ensure non-violence, access to health, confidentiality, police accountability, and equal access to essential services, while relevant agencies continue legal and policy review in accordance with national processes.

D. Sorcery Accusation Related Violence (SARV)

1. Policy and legislative reforms on SARV

41. PNG continues to strengthen its response to SARV through implementation of the National Action Plan Against Sorcery Accusation Related Violence (NAPSARV) 2024-2029. The Government reviewed the initial NAPSARV endorsed in 2015 to assess implementation progress and emerging challenges. The revised NAPSARV 2024-2029 was endorsed by NEC and provides a coordinated whole-of-government framework for addressing SARV and focuses on five thematic areas: care and counselling, advocacy, health, legal protection and prosecution, and research. An additional component on governance, monitoring and evaluation has been incorporated.

42. The Government has undertaken significant legislative reforms to strengthen accountability for SARV-related offences. Amendments to the *Criminal Code Act* introduced new provisions (Sections 520A-520G) criminalising the activities of persons commonly known as *glassman* or *glassmeri* who falsely accuse others of practicing sorcery and incite violence, torture and killings. The amendments also target persons who instigate, facilitate or benefit from sorcery accusation-related violence. These reforms were informed by recommendations arising from public hearings conducted by the Special Parliamentary Committee on Gender-Based Violence and SARV and are intended to dismantle networks that exploit cultural beliefs for personal gain.

2. Investigation, prosecution and accountability

43. The Government continues to promote accountability through the investigation and prosecution of SARV-related offences. In *State v Mon* (2025) N11225, the National Court convicted the defendant of murder after he accused a woman of causing deaths and misfortunes through sorcery, leading to her killing in Morobe Province. In sentencing the Court emphasized the dangers of vigilante justice, community complicity in sorcery-related violence and the need for strong deterrent measures against such offences.

3. Victim protection and survivor support

44. The Government recognises that accountability for SARV continues to be affected by underreporting, withdrawal of complaints, social pressure, fear of retaliation, reliance on informal settlements, limited police and prosecutorial capacity and geographical barriers to accessing justice. Through NAPSARV, priority is being given to strengthening survivor-centered responses, including access to protection, counselling, healthcare and justice services.

45. The Government continues to improve investigation and prosecution outcomes through training and capacity-building programmes for police officers, prosecutors, courts, village courts, health workers, social workers and community leaders. These efforts seek to strengthen legal protection mechanisms and improve access to justice for victims and survivors of SARV.

4. Prevention, awareness and community engagement

46. The Government continues to expand prevention efforts through sustained community engagement and public awareness programmes aimed at addressing harmful beliefs and social norms associated with sorcery accusations and violence.

47. SARV prevention initiatives are being implemented alongside broader measures under the National Strategy to Prevent and Respond to Gender-Based Violence 2026-2035, the National Ending Violence Against Children (EVAC) Roadmap, and child protection and GBV case management frameworks. The Government will continue to promote awareness through schools, communities and public campaigns to address harmful practices, including sorcery accusations, violence against women and children, child marriage and harmful bride price-related practices.

E. Human trafficking and contemporary forms of slavery, refugees, asylum seekers and internally displaced persons

48. PNG continues efforts to combat human trafficking and contemporary forms of slavery through legislative; policy and institutional measures aimed at preventing trafficking, protecting victims and strengthening investigation and prosecution of offenders. The Government continues to implement trafficking-related offences under the Criminal Code and work with law enforcement agencies, civil society organisations and international partners to address trafficking risks and exploitation.

49. The Government has decided to ratify the United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime, and it will now go through the domestic process for ratification.

50. The National Human Trafficking Action Committee updated the National Action Plan on Human Trafficking, and a country assessment was completed with support for training and mentoring of relevant agencies and civil society partners.

51. Efforts continue to improve victim identification, referral and protection mechanisms, particularly for women, children and other vulnerable persons who may be at risk of trafficking, forced labour and sexual exploitation. The Government also continues to support awareness and training initiatives for law enforcement officers and frontline service providers to improve prevention and response measures.

52. The Government continues to make efforts to ensure that asylum seekers and refugees, including West Papuans, are registered in government systems and have appropriate documentation. The Government also recognizes the need to document births of forcibly displaced persons and to ensure access to essential services on a non-discriminatory basis. Further legal and policy review is needed on accession to the Convention relating to the Status of Stateless Persons and the Convention on the Reduction of Statelessness.

53. Internal displacement remains a significant concern in the context of tribal conflict, disasters, climate impacts, urban evictions and development projects. The Government will continue to strengthen policy work on internal displacement in accordance with the National Policy on Internal Displacement launched in 2026, and the UN Guiding Principles on Internal Displacement.

F. Rights of the child

1. Protection of the child against abuse and exploitation

54. PNG continues to advance the protection of children through implementation of the *Lukautim Pikinini Act* 2015 (LPA), child protection policies and community-based child welfare programmes. Efforts focus on preventing child abuse, neglect, violence and exploitation, improving reporting, case management and referral services, and enhancing coordination between government agencies, service providers and community-based organisations.

55. The Government is implementing the national Ending Violence Against Children (EVAC) Roadmap, child protection standard operating procedures, and child protection and gender-based violence case management frameworks to improve prevention, response and support services for children at risk of abuse and exploitation. These measures seek to ensure that child protection services are accessible, adequately coordinated and available throughout the country, including in rural and remote communities.

56. With support from UN and development partners, the Government submitted its combined second and third periodic reports under the Convention on the Rights of the Child in April 2024 after a prolonged reporting gap. In 2025, the Government contributed to the global consultation to elaborate the Committee on the Rights of the Child's draft general comment on children's access to justice and effective remedies. This was based on national consultations with children and stakeholders. These processes have strengthened national awareness of child-sensitive justice, remedies and participation.

57. The Special Parliamentary Committee on Children and Youth Wellbeing was established in 2025, serving as a dedicated committee of the Papua New Guinea National Parliament to strengthen parliamentary leadership, oversight, and accountability for issues affecting children and young people.

2. Child marriage

58. PNG continues to implement measures aimed at preventing and eliminating child, early and forced marriage. The Government recognises child marriage as a harmful practice that negatively affects the health, education and development of children, particularly girls. Efforts continue through legal reforms, public awareness programmes, community engagement and child protection initiatives to address the social and cultural factors contributing to child marriage. These efforts are implemented in partnership with communities, churches, civil society organisations and development partners.

59. The Government continues to review and harmonise the legal framework relating to marriage, including the *Marriage Act* (Chapter 280) and the *Matrimonial Causes Act* 1963, in response to accepted recommendations calling for the abolition of exceptions to the minimum age of marriage and the strengthening of measures to end child marriage. These efforts are complemented by the LPA, which provides protection for children from harmful practices, abuse and exploitation, and promotes the best interests of the child in all matters affecting children.

3. Birth registration and legal identity

60. PNG continues to improve its civil registration and identity management systems. Birth registration remains critical for the protection of children's rights and facilitates access to education, healthcare and other essential services. Official child-related SDG data indicate that only 13 per cent of children under five were registered with a civil authority in 2018, leaving many children without documentation.

61. The Government enacted the *Civil Registration and Identity Management Act* 2024, which modernises the legal framework governing civil registration and identity management in PNG. The Act enhances the registration of births, deaths and other vital events and supports operational decentralization and the development of a comprehensive national identity system.

62. The Government is scaling up the National Identity Programme, online ward registration and linkages with maternity medical systems, prioritizing outreach to rural and remote communities, children in displacement settings, children of refugees and asylum seekers, and children at risk of statelessness.

4. Juvenile justice reform

63. PNG continues to implement the *Juvenile Justice Act* 2014, which promotes diversion, rehabilitation and reintegration of children in conflict with the law and incorporates child-sensitive justice principles. The Act emphasizes alternatives to detention and seeks to ensure that children are treated in a manner consistent with their dignity and best interests.

64. The Government continues to review legal frameworks to raise the minimum age of criminal responsibility to 14 years and continues to consider legislative reforms to align its juvenile justice framework with international standards. Efforts also continue to strengthen diversionary measures, community-based rehabilitation programmes and alternatives to detention for children in conflict with the law.

G. Right to health

1. Universal health care

65. PNG continues to pursue access to universal health care coverage through the implementation of the National Health Plan 2021-2030 (NHP), which aims to improve the availability, accessibility and quality of essential health services for all citizens, particularly women, children and populations living in rural and remote communities. According to the Sector Performance Annual Review 2023 (SPAR 2023), the Universal Health Coverage Service Coverage Index increased from 41 in 2019 to 46 in 2023, while health worker density increased from 11 to 15 health workers per 10,000 population over the same period.

66. The Government continues to implement targeted initiatives aimed at improving access to healthcare services for women, children and other vulnerable groups. This includes implementation of the Child Nutrition and Social Protection Project, a government-led initiative funded by the World Bank and supported by development partners. The Project supports PNG's efforts to reduce stunting and improve maternal and child health outcomes through community-based nutrition services, nutrition education, breastfeeding promotion and social protection interventions targeting vulnerable households during the first 1,000 days of a child's life.

2. Health and financing infrastructure

67. The Government has significantly increased investment in the health sector to improve access to quality healthcare services and strengthen health infrastructure. Health sector funding increased from approximately K2.5 billion in 2022 to K3.2 billion in 2026, representing an increase of approximately 28% over the reporting period. Increased funding has supported Provincial Health Authorities, medical supplies, vaccines, hospital infrastructure, district health facilities and Church Health Services, which provide a significant proportion of healthcare services in rural and remote communities.

68. The Government has prioritised investments in hospital and health facility infrastructure, including funding for district and provincial hospital programmes, specialised health services and improvements to medical supply systems. In 2025, funding was allocated for the construction and upgrading of district and provincial hospitals, cancer and cardiac treatment facilities, regional medical stores and community health worker training.

69. Additional investments have been directed towards strengthening rural health service delivery through Provincial Health Authorities and Church Health Services, which provide a substantial proportion of frontline healthcare services in rural and remote communities. In 2026, funding for Church Health Services increased by 22 per cent to support continued delivery of essential health services in underserved areas.

70. These measures contribute to improving access to healthcare services, strengthening health infrastructure and supporting implementation of universal health coverage, particularly for women, children, persons living with HIV and populations in rural and remote communities.

71. Despite the progress, service delivery remains constrained by infrastructure deficits, workforce shortages and geographical barriers. In 2023, only 54% of health posts were operational, while 38% of health facilities had running water available in delivery rooms.

3. Sexual and reproductive health

72. PNG continues to improve access to sexual and reproductive health services through implementation of the National Sexual and Reproductive Health Policy, Family Planning Policy, National Youth and Adolescent Health Policy, and related programmes under the NHP. These initiatives aim to strengthen access to family planning, reproductive health information and services, and maternal and adolescent health care.

73. The Government has also expanded prevention initiatives targeting adolescent girls, including implementation of the Human Papilloma Virus Vaccine (HPVV) Programme, which aims to reduce the future incidence of cervical cancer. Reproductive health programmes continue to support awareness of safe sexual practices, prevention of sexually transmitted infections and access to reproductive healthcare services.

74. Despite ongoing efforts, challenges remain in ensuring equitable access to sexual and reproductive health services, particularly for adolescents and those living in rural and remote communities. The Government remains committed to strengthening reproductive health services, family planning programmes and adolescent health interventions nationwide.

75. PNG continues to ensure access to maternal health services through antenatal care, skilled birth attendance and maternal health programmes implemented under the NHP. According to SPAR 2023, 29% of pregnant women received at least four antenatal care visits and 42% of births were supervised by skilled health personnel. The prevalence of low birthweight was reported at 8% in 2023. The Government is committed to ensuring that access to maternal health services through public health facilities, outreach services and community-based healthcare programmes, reaches women and girls living in rural and remote communities.

76. The 2016-18 Demographic and Health Survey reported a maternal mortality ratio of 171 maternal deaths per 100,000 live births for the seven years preceding the survey. In this light, the Government will continue to expand sexual and reproductive health, maternal, newborn and child health services by addressing staffing, referral, supply chain and quality gaps. The Government also recognizes the importance of mental health services, leprosy-related stigma reduction, climate-resilient health systems and environmentally sustainable health care facilities. The government is working closely with development partners to implement key interventions aimed at scaling up primary healthcare to reduce maternal and newborn mortality such as ante-natal care to encourage a 1st to 4th visit, improve quality of care, enhance supervised delivery, obstetric and newborn care and uptake of family planning services.

4. HIV/AIDS

77. The Prime Minister declared a National HIV Crisis in June 2025 to draw attention to the sharp rise in HIV infections. The Government has increased domestic resources for the HIV response in line with the National STI and HIV Strategy, from K14 million to K17.5 million per year. The NEC approved emergency funding of K50.4 million for HIV, tuberculosis and malaria for 2025-2027 with an additional commitment of domestic resources of over 1.5 million USD per year for 2026-2027 for Reproductive Health Commodity Security. All aspects of the HIV/AIDS interventions are being prioritized, including a commitment to addressing stigma with self-testing HIV kits.

78. The Government is strengthening the National AIDS Council Secretariat, community-led monitoring, re-engagement of people lost to follow-up, and partnerships with churches, key population organizations and civil society. The National STI and HIV Strategy addresses stigma, discrimination, gender inequality, and sexual violence.

79. PNG continues to strengthen prevention efforts and ensure stigma-free treatment and care services for people at risk of or living with HIV through implementation of national HIV programmes and broader health sector interventions. Efforts include HIV testing, antiretroviral treatment services and prevention of mother-to-child transmission programmes. SPAR 2023 continues to monitor HIV prevalence among pregnant women aged 15–24 years and access to antiretroviral treatment services as key national indicators.

5. Leprosy

80. PNG continues efforts to eliminate leprosy and address stigma and other barriers faced by persons affected by leprosy through early case detection, treatment, contact tracing and preventive treatment programmes under the National Leprosy Control Programme. These efforts are supported through partnerships with health service providers and civil society organisations to improve access to healthcare and reduce stigma and discrimination. The Government continues to work with health service providers, provincial health authorities and organisations such as The Leprosy Mission Papua New Guinea to improve access to healthcare services and support the social inclusion of persons affected by leprosy and their families.

81. The Government has expanded the use of Single Dose Rifampicin Post-Exposure Prophylaxis (SDR-PEP) for eligible contacts of persons affected by leprosy and continues active case-finding and screening activities in high-burden communities. These measures aim to strengthen early intervention and improve access to treatment, particularly in rural and remote areas.

6. Rural and remote health services

82. Improving healthcare access in rural and remote communities remains a national priority. The Government continues to support service delivery through health centres, community health posts, outreach clinics and Church Health Services, which play a critical role in delivering healthcare to hard-to-reach populations. These services provide maternal and child health care, immunisation, HIV services, health promotion and other essential healthcare interventions.

83. According to SPAR 2023, only 54 per cent of health posts were operational, reflecting continuing challenges associated with infrastructure, transportation, communications and workforce shortages. The Government remains committed to strengthening rural health infrastructure, expanding outreach services and increasing access to healthcare for women, children and other vulnerable groups throughout the country.

H. Right to education

1. Access to quality education

84. PNG continues to implement the National Education Plan 2020-2029 to improve access, equity, quality and relevance across all levels of education. The Government remains

committed to ensuring inclusive and equitable quality education through sustained investment in the education sector, school fee support programmes, teacher recruitment and training, school infrastructure development and targeted interventions for disadvantaged learners. Education sector funding increased to K4.435 billion in 2025, representing a 12 per cent increase over the previous year.

85. Progress has been made to improve participation and completion rates across the education system. According to the PNG Education Indicator Dashboard, the Gross Enrolment Rate (Prep to Grade 8) reached 98.3%, while the Net Enrolment Rate (Prep to Grade 8) reached 74.0%. The Gross Completion Rate reached 65%, reflecting continued improvements in retention and progression through basic education. Participation in secondary education has also improved. According to UNESCO Institute for Statistics data, gross secondary school enrolment increased from 45.8% in 2021 to 52.1% in 2023, reflecting continued progress in expanding access to secondary education.

86. The Government continues to implement measures aimed at increasing participation and retention across all levels of education. These include support for school fee subsidies, teacher recruitment, curriculum development and investments in school infrastructure and learning resources. These measures contribute to the progressive realization of universal access to education and support efforts to improve educational outcomes for all children.

87. The policy framework for inclusive education has been strengthened through the Gender Equity and Social Inclusion in Schools Policy; the Behaviour Management Policy; the Inclusive Education Policy; Early Childhood Policy and the Standards-Based Curriculum. However, exclusion of certain population groups remains. With UNFPA and OHCHR support, the National Department of Education developed comprehensive sexuality education student learning exemplars and a teachers' manual, which are undergoing internal review and approval.

88. National planning inputs record improvements between 2019 and 2024 in primary enrolment, gender parity, grade 8 completion, adult literacy and flexible learning enrolment. The 2025 VNR records improvements in enrolment, gender parity and alternative learning pathways, but the secondary Gender Parity Index has not yet reached 1.00; official data also shows FODE enrolment increasing from 35,513 in 2020 to 82,877 in 2022. Nevertheless, the Government acknowledges that the quality and completion of education continue to be affected by teacher shortages, inadequate infrastructure, and limited coverage of inclusive education. As a result, learning outcomes remain suboptimal, while indirect education costs continue to pose significant barriers, particularly for girls, children with disabilities, and children living in rural, remote, and conflict-affected areas.

89. Since 2023, the Government continues to implement and monitor the Improved Technical and Vocational Education and Training for Employment Project (iTVET4E), co-funded by the Asian Development Bank (ADB) and the Australian Government.

2. Education in rural and remote communities

90. While the Government continues to implement the Government Free Education Policy, which covers tuition and project fees for students enrolled in registered schools and prohibits exclusion for non-payment of fees, provision of free basic and secondary education must be reflected in the legal framework through the Education Act. Funding allocations consider geographical accessibility through the PNG Access Remote Index. FODE provides alternative pathways for learners who are out of school or unable to access conventional schooling.

91. Through ongoing investments in schools, classrooms and learning facilities, the Government seeks to reduce disparities in educational access between urban and rural communities. These measures are supported by broader infrastructure and connectivity initiatives which aim to improve access to basic services, including education, in underserved areas.

3. Out-of-school children and youth

92. PNG continues efforts to address barriers affecting out-of-school children through education sector reforms and programmes aimed at increasing participation, retention and progression through the education system. Efforts have focused on improving access to education for children in rural and remote communities, reducing barriers to school attendance and supporting children who have disengaged from formal education.

93. The Government continues to support school attendance and re-entry through school fee support programmes, community awareness initiatives and alternative learning pathways such as FODE. These measures aim to improve access to education for children who have left school and those at risk of dropping out.

94. The Government has also ensured that school attendance was restored and classes have been back to normal since then following disruptions associated with the COVID-19 pandemic through targeted awareness initiatives and community engagement programmes.

95. Despite these efforts, out-of-school children remain a challenge. Available data indicate that approximately 53,289 primary school-aged children remained out of school in 2021, underscoring the importance of continued interventions to improve participation and retention, particularly in rural and remote communities.

4. Inclusive education for children with disabilities and children affected by leprosy

96. PNG continues to ensure accessible inclusive education through implementation of the National Inclusive Education Policy 2019-2029, the National Education Plan 2020-2029, and the Disability Services Act 2025. These frameworks support access to quality education, reasonable accommodation and inclusive learning opportunities for children with disabilities.

97. The Government has established and supported Special Education Resource Centres (SERCs) across the country to provide specialised educational support, assessment services, teacher assistance and learning resources for children with disabilities. These centres also support the identification and placement of children with special learning needs within mainstream education settings.

98. The Government continues to strengthen teacher capacity through pre-service and in-service training programmes on inclusive education and disability support. Efforts have focused on equipping teachers and schools to better meet the needs of children with physical, sensory, intellectual and developmental disabilities and to promote inclusive learning environments.

99. The enactment of the *Disability Services Act* 2025 further supports the legal framework supporting the inclusion and participation of persons with disabilities, including access to education on an equal basis with others. The Government continues to work with disability organisations, schools and development partners to improve access to educational opportunities and reduce barriers affecting children with disabilities and leprosy related disabilities.

I. Rights of persons with disabilities

1. Legislative and policy framework

100. The National Parliament unanimously enacted the *Disability Services Act* 2025, establishing a strengthened legal framework for the protection, inclusion and participation of persons with disabilities. The Act promotes a rights-based approach to disability and provides a foundation for improved coordination of disability services and programmes across government sectors. As required by the Act, the establishment of the Office for Disability Services under the Department for Community Development and Religion is underway and expected to be completed in the next 12 months.

101. The Government has taken steps, including the allocation of transitional funding for 2026, to update the National Disability Policy, establish effectively functioning disability advisory committees from the national to the district levels, strengthen the Office for

Disability Services under DFCDR, improve government and private sector financing, and build systems for disability data and monitoring in compliance with the CRPD. Furthermore, a pioneering multi-year Public Investment Plan is currently under consideration to accelerate the implementation of the Disability Services Act 2025.

102. The Government is working to update the National Disability Policy, which expired in 2025. The updated Policy will guide national efforts to promote accessibility, equality, non-discrimination and the full participation of persons with disabilities in society. The Policy supports the integration of disability inclusion across national planning, service delivery and development programmes.

2. Institutional development and disability governance

103. The Government has continued efforts to enhance institutional efforts to realize the rights of all persons with disabilities. With the support of the Government of Australia, the Government, the United Nations and the PNG Assembly of Disabled Persons launched a joint programme in March 2026 to strengthen disability governance and data systems. This supports the implementation of the *Disability Services Act* 2025, CRPD reporting, and the use of Washington Group Questions to expand disability data. Under this joint programme, the Government is advancing work on a national baseline disability survey and securing effective governance and funding support for provincial and district-level disability service centres, assistive devices, rehabilitation, inclusive education, accessibility standards, transport access and universal design.

104. The NSO has presented the findings of an in-depth analysis of disability data from the 2022 Socio-Demographic and Economic Survey (SDES), providing the country's clearest national picture yet of the lives and experiences of persons with disabilities.

3. Employment and social inclusion

105. PNG continues to promote the economic participation and social inclusion of persons with disabilities through policies and programmes designed to improve access to education, skills development, employment and livelihood opportunities. Efforts focus on reducing discrimination and removing barriers that limit the participation of persons with disabilities in the workforce and broader community life.

106. The Government recognises the importance of expanding pathways from education and training into employment and continues to work with stakeholders to improve opportunities for persons with disabilities to participate fully in economic and social development. These efforts are complemented by awareness and advocacy initiatives aimed at reducing stigma and promoting recognition of the rights, abilities and contributions of persons with disabilities.

4. Persons affected by leprosy-related disabilities

107. PNG continues to support persons affected by leprosy-related disabilities through measures aimed at improving access to healthcare, education, employment and community participation. Efforts to reduce stigma and discrimination are undertaken through awareness programmes, health services and partnerships with organisations working with persons affected by leprosy and their families. These measures contribute to ensuring that persons affected by leprosy-related disabilities are able to enjoy their rights and participate in society on an equal basis with others.

J. Environment and climate change

1. Environmental governance

108. PNG remains committed to advancing environmental protection through the *Environment Act* 2000, the Conservation and Environment Protection Authority Act 2014, the *Climate Change (Management) Act* 2015 and the recent *Protected Areas Act* 2024.

109. The Protected Areas Act 2024 establishes a national framework for the declaration, management and expansion of protected areas and supports the national target of protecting 30% of PNG terrestrial and marine areas by 2030. Recognising that an estimated 97% of land in PNG is under customary ownership, the Act enables customary landowners to voluntarily partner with the Conservation and Environment Protection Authority (CEPA) in establishing protected areas through the principle of free, prior and informed consent (FPIC).

110. Environmental oversight continues through environmental impact assessments, permitting requirements, compliance monitoring and enforcement activities administered by CEPA, while environmental management, rehabilitation and biodiversity conservation programmes continue to be implemented across major development projects.

2. Sustainable forestry and community rights

111. PNG continues to promote forestry and conservation activities in a manner that respects the rights and interests of customary landowners and local communities. The *Protected Areas Act* 2024 reinforces the principle of free, prior and informed consent (FPIC) and recognises the central role of customary landowners in decisions relating to the management and conservation of land and natural resources.

112. Forestry and land-use activities continue to be subject to environmental assessment, public consultation and regulatory oversight processes administered by the Conservation and Environment Protection Authority (CEPA). These measures support community participation in decision-making, safeguard customary land rights and promote sustainable use of forest resources.

113. The Government also supports community-based conservation initiatives and sustainable livelihood opportunities aimed at ensuring that local community's benefit from the protection and sustainable management of forest resources while maintaining ownership and control over their customary land.

3. Climate change adaptation and resilience

114. PNG remains highly vulnerable to the impacts of climate change, including sea-level rise, extreme weather events, ocean acidification and threats to food security, livelihoods and biodiversity. Guided by the *Climate Change (Management) Act* 2015 and the National Adaptation Plan, the Government continues to adopt a whole-of-government approach to climate resilience by integrating climate risk considerations into agriculture, health, transport, infrastructure and disaster risk reduction planning.

115. Climate adaptation initiatives continue to support climate-resilient infrastructure, resilient water supply systems, climate-smart agriculture and community-based adaptation measures, particularly in vulnerable and rural communities. The Government also promotes inclusive participation in climate-related decision-making, including the involvement of women, customary landowners, local communities and persons with disabilities.

4. International climate advocacy

116. PNG continues to advocate for stronger global action on climate change through active regional and international engagement. In 2024, PNG participated in proceedings before the International Court of Justice concerning States' obligations in relation to climate change, joining other Pacific Island countries in highlighting the disproportionate impacts of climate change on vulnerable nations and communities.

117. PNG remains committed to strengthening environmental governance, building climate resilience, protecting biodiversity and promoting sustainable development, while continuing to address challenges associated with resource constraints, technical capacity and the increasing impacts of climate change on communities and ecosystems.

K. Administration of justice and the rule of law

118. In 2023, Parliament passed an amendment of the Criminal Code to abolish the death penalty and replace it with life imprisonment. The Government will continue to review the implications of ratifying the Second Optional Protocol to the ICCPR.

1. Access to justice and legal aid services

119. PNG continues to improve access to justice through the expansion of legal aid services and justice infrastructure. The Office of the Public Solicitor is currently established in 19 of the country's 22 provinces, with a new branch opened in Jiwaka Province in 2025. Plans are underway to establish additional offices in Western and Hela Provinces, while residents of Central Province continue to access services through the National Capital District office. The Office of the Public Solicitor provides free legal assistance to eligible persons and remains a key mechanism for ensuring access to justice, particularly for vulnerable and disadvantaged groups.

120. The Government has also expanded access to justice through the establishment of Community Justice Centres, deployment of judges and magistrates, and operationalisation of the new National and Supreme Court Complex in Port Moresby, which has strengthened the capacity of justice institutions and improved service delivery.

2. Police accountability and oversight

121. PNG remains committed to addressing allegations of misconduct by law enforcement personnel and strengthening police accountability mechanisms. The Royal Papua New Guinea Constabulary Internal Affairs Division, also known as the Internal Investigation Unit (IIU), is mandated to investigate complaints involving mistreatment, torture, excessive use of force, arbitrary or unlawful detention, unlawful killings and sexual violence by police officers. Where allegations are substantiated, matters are referred through the appropriate investigative and prosecutorial processes in accordance with the Criminal Code Act 1974, Police Act 1998 and constitutional protections for fundamental rights and freedoms. The Government continues to work with oversight institutions, civil society organisations and development partners to improve police conduct, accountability and compliance with the rule of law.

122. Additionally, the *Wrongs (Miscellaneous Provisions) Act* 1975 and the Claims By and Against the State Act 1996. The amendments clarify that where a public servant, including a police officer, acts outside the scope of their lawful duties, that individual may be personally liable for their conduct and the State will not automatically bear vicarious liability for such actions. These reforms reinforce individual accountability within the public service and law enforcement agencies.

L. Economic social and cultural rights

123. PNG remains committed to progressively realising the right to an adequate standard of living through implementation of Vision 2050, the Medium-Term Development Plan IV (2023-2027) and sector-specific policies aligned with the Sustainable Development Goals. The Government continues to promote sustainable economic and social development through investments in infrastructure, service delivery, education, healthcare and community development programmes aimed at improving living standards and reducing inequalities, particularly for vulnerable populations.

124. The Government continues to improve access to essential services through investments in transportation, water supply, sanitation, telecommunications and other public infrastructure. Ongoing implementation of the Connect PNG Programme and related infrastructure initiatives seek to improve connectivity, expand access to services and markets, and support inclusive development, particularly in rural and underserved communities.

125. PNG continues to strengthen food security, nutrition and household resilience through agricultural development, climate-resilient livelihood programmes and community-based

interventions. The Government is implementing the Child Nutrition and Social Protection Project.

126. The Government recognizes the importance of social protection in reducing poverty and vulnerability. Programmes continue to support women, children, youth, older persons, persons with disabilities and other vulnerable groups through targeted assistance, community-based interventions and inclusive development initiatives. The Government will continue to advance coordinated approaches to poverty reduction, social protection, employment, housing and basic service delivery to ensure that no one is left behind.

127. The Special Parliamentary Committee on Customary Land and Land Reform advanced important recommendations encapsulated by a draft customary land reform bill anchored on the principle of free, prior and informed consent and stronger protection of customary land rights. Parliament's unanimous endorsement of the Committee's report in 2026 provides an opportunity to align land reform with human rights, anti-corruption, environmental protection and inclusive development.

III. Achievements, good practices and challenges

128. Preparation of the fourth-cycle report highlighted several good practices, including the thematic clustering of accepted recommendations, the inter-agency facilitation workshop held in Port Moresby in February 2026, the use of lead-agency implementation matrices to assess progress and identify gaps, and broad-based consultations involving government institutions, constitutional offices, civil society organisations, faith-based organisations, organisations of persons with disabilities, women, youth, development partners and the UN system.

129. The review process demonstrated significant progress in several areas, including implementation of the *Disability Services Act* 2025, enactment of the *Protected Areas Act* 2024, adoption of the Human Rights Strategic Plan 2024-2029, launch of the National Human Rights Policy, endorsement of the National Action Plan Against Sorcery Accusation Related Violence 2024-2029, expansion of birth registration and legal identity systems, strengthening of legal aid services, and continued investments in health, education and social protection programmes.

130. Despite these achievements, implementation challenges remain significant. PNG's geographical dispersion, difficult terrain, linguistic and cultural diversity, infrastructure limitations and decentralised service-delivery environment continue to affect implementation across sectors. Fiscal constraints, workforce shortages, limited institutional capacity, weak data systems, climate-related impacts and disaster events also affect the delivery of services and the progressive realisation of human rights.

131. Persistent challenges remain in preventing and responding to GBV and SARV, increasing women's participation in leadership and decision-making, expanding disability inclusion and equity, increasing birth registration coverage, improving access to health and education services in remote communities, strengthening police accountability and improving access to justice, limited access to public information, and limited protection of whistleblowers, witnesses, journalists and human rights defenders. Additional efforts are also required to address internal displacement, environmental pressures, climate-related vulnerabilities and service-delivery challenges affecting rural and vulnerable communities.

IV. Key national priorities

132. PNG will continue implementation of the Human Rights Strategic Plan 2024-2029 and the National Human Rights Policy, while progressing measures towards the establishment of an independent and Paris Principles-compliant National Human Rights Institution. The Government will also continue to support the NMIRF to improve coordination of implementation, reporting and follow-up of international human rights obligations through strengthened institutional arrangements and human rights data systems.

133. The Government will continue implementation of the National Strategy to Prevent and Respond to Gender-Based Violence 2026-2035, the National Action Plan Against Sorcery Accusation Related Violence 2024-2029, and the national Ending Violence Against Children Roadmap, with emphasis on prevention, protection, accountability and survivor-centered support services.

134. The Government will continue to promote gender equality and women's participation in public and political life through implementation of the Gender Equality and Women's Empowerment Policy 2025-2035, leadership development initiatives and implementation of amendments to the Organic Law on the Integrity of Political Parties and Candidates 2001, which require political parties to endorse women candidates.

135. The Government will continue implementation of the Disability Services Act 2025, the National Inclusive Education Policy 2019-2029, and measures to improve accessibility, disability inclusion, birth registration, legal identity and child protection services, particularly for vulnerable and marginalised groups.

136. The Government will continue to improve health, education and social protection outcomes through implementation of the National Health Plan 2021-2030, National Education Plan 2020-2029, National Nutrition Policy 2016-2026, and other national development frameworks, with particular focus on rural and remote communities, women, children, youth and persons with disabilities.

137. The Government will prioritize development of the next National Anti-Corruption Plan of Action (2026-2030), National Anti-Corruption Strategy prior to expiration of the current Strategy (2026-2030), merit-based recruitments in public sector, strengthened protection of whistleblowers, witnesses, journalist, trade unionists and human rights defenders, and access to public information through the Right to Information Policy and Right to Information Act.

138. The Government will continue efforts to improve access to justice, enhance court efficiency, expand legal aid services, strengthen police accountability, combat corruption through the Independent Commission Against Corruption, and promote transparency and public participation through access-to-information reforms and good governance initiatives.

139. The Government will continue to integrate human rights into climate change, disaster risk reduction, environmental protection, customary land reform, urban planning, relocation and resettlement, large-scale development projects and business activities. It will consider development of a national action plan on business and human rights and strengthen free, prior and informed consent, environmental and social safeguards, public disclosure and remedies.

140. The Government will continue preparations for peaceful, safe, inclusive and credible 2027 national election.

141. The Government will continue to review treaty ratification and reporting priorities, including technical assessment of remaining core human rights treaties and optional protocols, legal alignment, implementation capacity, public awareness and ongoing engagement with United Nations mechanisms.

V. Capacity building and technical assistance

142. PNG welcomes continued technical assistance to support implementation of measures addressing gender-based violence, sorcery accusation-related violence, violence against children, child protection, victim support services, legal aid and survivor-centered justice mechanisms.

143. Technical assistance is also sought to support the establishment and operationalisation of the National Human Rights Institution, strengthening of human rights reporting and implementation through the NMIRF, development of disaggregated data systems, anti-corruption and transparency strengthening, and enhancement of institutional capacity across the justice and governance sectors.

144. Further cooperation is welcomed in the areas of health systems strengthening, maternal and child health, disability inclusion, birth registration, education quality, social protection, climate adaptation, disaster preparedness, environmental governance, sustainable development and community resilience, particularly in rural and remote areas.

VI. Conclusion

145. PNG remains committed to the progressive realization of human rights and fundamental freedoms for all persons. The fourth-cycle reporting process has provided an opportunity to assess progress, identify implementation gaps and strengthen collaboration across Government, constitutional institutions, civil society organisations, development partners and communities.

146. The Government recognises that sustainable progress requires continued commitment, effective coordination and inclusive participation at all levels. PNG is now at its 50th year of Independence, and it remains committed to ensuring that human rights considerations are integrated across national laws, policies, institutions and development priorities, while responding to the evolving needs of its people and communities.

147. PNG reaffirms its commitment to constructive engagement with the Human Rights Council, United Nations human rights mechanisms, regional organisations and development partners. The Government looks forward to continued cooperation and dialogue in advancing the promotion, protection and fulfilment of human rights and in supporting a peaceful, inclusive and resilient future for all Papua New Guineans.